My Sergei

By Ekaterina Gordeeva

Not long ago I heard someone ask a friend, "If you had to live your life over again, what would you do differently?" I've thought about this, and for me, I'd like to live my life over again backward. Any day I'm living now, I would exchange for any day in the past because I know that for me to find the kind of happiness I had with Sergei isn't possible. It's like trying to find the comet that was in the night sky last spring, which passes Earth once in seventeen thousand years. No matter what lies ahead, the best years of my life will have been with my Seriozha, and those years are now laid to rest.

INTRODUCTION

In the former Soviet Union, the sports establishment, charged with producing winners for the greater glory of the empire, had almost unlimited power over the athletically gifted. Children as young as five or six were identified, sent to special schools and given rigorous training in the sports

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in which they were expected to excel. Two such youngsters were Ekaterina Gordeeva and Sergei Grinkov, paired as skaters by their teachers when they were 11 and 14. As time passed and their joint career led to international championships, they fell in love and married. Their success culminated in Olympic gold medals in 1990 and 1994. And then, suddenly, Grinkov died of a heart attack in 1995 at age 28. The story of their love and their happiness together is deeply moving. My Sergei by Ekaterina Gordeeva

God took Sergei without warning – a heart attack on November 20, 1995. I lost my husband and best friend. I lost my favorite thing to do, because now I had no skating partner. It's like I was living in a fairy tale before, and now I've been abandoned in a wild forest.

That is what life with Sergei was like, a fairy tale. It began the year I turned eleven. The pairs coach where I had skated since I was four, told me to come early to practice one day. He had chosen a skating partner for me. I was very excited because I knew it was going to be Sergei.

As a pairs skater, you have to learn everything you learned as a singles skater over again because you

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have to align your body with your partner's. Sergei and I practiced the jumps endlessly. I was never scared of the lifts because I always felt very safe in Sergei's arms. I'm not sure why, but once we were paired, I always believed Sergei was the only one who could skate with me.

Several years passed, we both grew up and we began preparing for the 1988 Olympics. As the games approached, everything became a little more stressful, a little more intense. In mid-November, during practice for an exhibition, Sergei caught his blade in a soft rut in the ice while holding me aloft and dropped me. The first part of my body to hit the ice was my forehead.

I didn't feel any pain at first, then my entire head felt like it was splitting apart. I blacked out and was driven to the hospital. I ended up staying for six days. I'd suffered quite a serious concussion. I was mad at Sergei because I thought this fall was his mistake. Then, there was a knock on the door, and it was Sergei.

He was carrying a dozen roses, and he was very, very upset. Sergei continued to visit me at home every

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dat. When at last I could skate again, I immediately noticed a change in the way he was holding me. Something had happened in those two weeks, and I realized that his thoughts for me had changed. Before we had been like two skaters. After that, we were a pair.

I wondered, why me? Why am I so lucky? I was so young and small and shy, and Sergei could have had any nice long-legged girl. Why should he choose me? I believed he would love me just for a little while, and then it would be over.

We went on to win the gold medal at the 1988 Olympics in Calgary, Canada. And the following year Sergei and I were married, and our daughter, Daria, was born a year and a half later. Then in 1994 we won our second Olympic gold medal. The first gold medal we had won for the Soviet Union. This one we won for each other.

In 1995, we were training in Lake Placid for a fifty-five-city tour with the Stars on Ice. At the beginning of the program, I'm on one knee, and Sergei is

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on one knee, and we are face-to-face. I put my head on his shoulder, and I remember that his T-shirt smelled very clean. So I said, "Humm, smells good." And he said, "Yes, it's clean" Just that. They were to be his last words.

Then we started to skate. We did the early movements – the camel spin into a lift. The full orchestra was just coming in. Sergei was gliding on the ice, but he didn't do the crossovers. His hand didn't go around my waist for the lift. I thought it was his back, which had been bothering him for some time. He was bent over slightly, and I asked him, "Is it your back?" He shook his head a little. He tried to stop, but he kept gliding into the boards. He was dizzy, but he didn't tell me what was happening. Then he bent his knees and ay down on the ice very carefully.

I kept asking what was happening. "What's wrong, Seriozha? What's the matter?" But he didn't tell me. He didn't speak at all.

Marina, our choreographer, stopped the music. When she came over to him, she knew right away it was

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something with his heart. It looked like he couldn't breathe anymore. She told me to all 911, and she started doing CPR on him. I was so scared. I was screaming. I don't know what. I forgot all the words in English. I couldn't remember the word for help. I ran, crying, to get someone to call 911 for me.

By the time I got back, everyone was around Sergei, and the medical people were working on him, trying to get his heart going. Then the medical people were taking him in the ambulance, and I only had time to get my skates off and pick up Sergei's bag.

SOURCE INFORMATION

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AWARD HISTORY

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